

MARCH 2026 · LITERATURE REVIEW

The Grotesque Body Politic

The Rabelaisian Grotesque in Irvine Welsh's Trainspotting

Dina Alkhateeb

There is a peculiar artistic audacity at the heart of Irvine Welsh's *Trainspotting*: the novel's most viscerally memorable passages are not its moments of intimacy or tenderness, but its scenes of faeces, vomit, and bodily collapse. Welsh's graphic attention to excrement, illness, and decay constitutes a coherent aesthetic and political argument—one rooted in what scholars of Renaissance literature have long called the Rabelaisian grotesque. Like François Rabelais's sixteenth-century carnival world of bodies in extremis, Welsh's Edinburgh is a place where the lower body (and its functions) becomes the site of comic subversion and protest. Welsh's abjection dismantles the sentimental, aspirational mythology of "Choose Life" consumer culture by making the body itself a counterargument, and in doing so, locates a coarse but real beauty in the grotesque vitality of its characters' existence.

To understand what Welsh is doing formally, it helps to have the Rabelaisian framework in mind. Rabelais's *Gargantua and Pantagruel* is saturated with bodily excess—feasting, defecation, urination, disease—deployed as satirical weapons against institutional hypocrisy within the Church, the law, and scholastic pretension as a whole. The grotesque body in Rabelais is carnivalesque, a body that overflows its own boundaries, and in doing so breaks down the polite hierarchies that keep ordinary people in their place. Welsh imports this tradition wholesale into the post-Thatcher Edinburgh housing schemes. His characters' bodies are spectacularly, comically, miserably uncontainable. They cannot hold themselves together, and that inability to hold together is a direct symptom of a society that has failed them. When Renton observes that the conventional citizen is headed towards "rotting away, pishing and shiteing yersel in a home, a total fuckin embarrassment tae the selfish, fucked-up brats ye've produced," he is pointing out that bodily dissolution awaits everyone—the mortgage-payer and the junkie alike. The difference is merely one of timing and self-awareness.

The novel's most celebrated set-piece, the "Worst Toilet in Scotland" sequence, is the clearest demonstration of Welsh's grotesque aesthetic at work. Renton has inserted opium suppositories rectally for the first time and, after leaving the dealer's flat at Muirhouse, immediately loses control of his bowels. He ducks into a bookmaker's lavatory, which Welsh describes as having "a good inch ay stagnant, spunky urine covering the flair," with a "seatless bowl fill ay broon water, toilet paper and lumps ay floating shite." The comedy here is Rabelaisian in the most precise sense: the body erupts through all attempts at social management, indifferent to dignity or propriety. But what elevates the scene beyond mere grotesquerie is what Renton does next. Having retrieved

his suppositories from the bowl—plunging his arms “right aroond the bend”—he kills a bluebottle fly and uses its crushed body as ink to spell “HIBS” on the toilet wall. He then pauses to reflect: “The vile bluebottle, which caused me a great deal of distress, has been transformed intae a work of art which gives me much pleasure tae look at. Ah am speculatively thinking about this as a positive metaphor for other things in my life.” Here, Welsh is making explicit what the whole novel argues implicitly: that beauty can emerge from filth. The grotesque body is not the negation of the aesthetic; it is its raw material.

Welsh reinforces this through the novel’s treatment of withdrawal and illness. “The First Day of the Edinburgh Festival,” in which Renton prepares his bare room for cold-turkey detox, is notable for its almost tender inventory: “Ten tins ay Heinz tomato soup, eight tins ay mushroom soup ... two boatils ay Milk of Magnesia, one boatil ay paracetamol ... three brown plastic buckets, half-filled wi a mixture ay disinfectant and water for ma shite, puke and pish.” There is something here that functions against sentimental realism. The list is practical, methodical, even loving—it has the quality of a craftsman laying out tools. The body in crisis becomes an object of careful, unsentimental attention. The “Junk Dilemmas” interludes, scattered throughout the novel, operate in a similar register. In “Junk Dilemmas No. 63,” Renton describes heroin as an internal sea: “This internal sea. The problem is that this beautiful ocean carries with it loads ay poisonous flotsam and jetsam ... that poison is diluted by the sea, but once the ocean rolls out, it leaves the shite behind, inside ma body.” The metaphor is genuinely poetic, yoking beauty and toxicity in a way that refuses the simple moral verdict (drugs are bad, bodies corrupted by drugs are shameful) that bourgeois realism would require. The body that is rotting is also, in some specific and defended way, a body that is alive.

Yet Welsh’s most powerful deployment of bodily imagery is not comic but tragic, and in “It Goes Without Saying”—the chapter in which baby Dawn is found dead in her cot—the grotesque logic of the novel reaches its darkest pitch. The visual detail is spare but devastating: “It wis lying face doon in its cot. It, naw, she, wis cauld and deid, blue aroond the eyes. Ah didnae huv tae touch her tae ken. Just lyin thair like a discarded wee doll.” The body here is entirely stilled, and that stillness is more disturbing than any of the novel’s more spectacular excretions. What is morally devastating about the scene is what surrounds it: the group’s immediate pivot to worrying about their drug supply, Lesley’s broken request for a shot even as her daughter lies dead in the next room. Welsh refuses to sentimentalise even here. The body of the dead child forces a confrontation with everything the novel has been accumulating: the costs of abjection when it is not a choice

but a condition. Renton can make art out of a dead fly on a toilet wall, but there is no transformative metaphor available for Dawn. Her death is the limit-case of the grotesque: the point at which the carnivalesque body stops being rebellious and becomes simply ruined.

Taken together, these scenes make a sustained case against the sentimental realism that would either wring its hands over the Edinburgh underclass or celebrate its resistance in comforting ways. Welsh does neither. The “Choose Life” monologue, embedded in “Feeling Free,” is the novel’s most explicit satirical address: consumer society’s promise is that you can avoid bodily dissolution if you just choose the right washing machines and game shows, but Renton knows, and Welsh insists, that the body will betray you regardless. You will end up “pishing and shiteing yersel in a home” either way. In this sense, the drug addicts’ bodies, with their spectacular incontinence and decay, are simply an accelerated, honest version of what everyone’s body does eventually. The grotesque in *Trainspotting* is normal life with the euphemisms stripped away. This is the positive aesthetic element of Welsh’s abjection: it is honest in a way that sentimental realism cannot be, and in its honesty—crude, funny, heartbreaking, occasionally beautiful—it insists that the people whose bodies it depicts deserve to be seen.